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(IN)SECURITY ZONES IN SOUTH LEBANON

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with the assistance of JILLIAN SCHWEDLER

This essay considers the dilemma of south Lebanon, a region enmeshed in regional conflict and an area where Lebanon's internal conflicts have reverberated and even exploded. The region, which borders Israel to the south and Syria to the east, has been for more than two decades a virtual battlefield where the inhabitants have been punished dearly for the accident of living in the crossfire between Israeli and Palestinian guns. As the peace process moves forward on other fronts, the fate of this region remains to be resolved.

Spasms of violence in southern Lebanon involving Israel and its enemies have become the norm, not to mention intra-Lebanese conflicts and Lebanese-Palestinian violence that has often, but not always, been an extension of the Arab-Israeli conflict. Long neglected by the government in Beirut, the south, with its absence of legitimate authority, has acted like a magnet for regional powers intent on engaging Israel without jeopardizing their own borders. Over the years, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, Libya, and Syria have found the pull of the south irresistible. For its part, Israel has been heavily involved there, using the area variously as a launching site for larger adventures in Lebanon and as a place for hunkering down and conducting forays, more or less at will, to preempt, punish, and intimidate its foes. More than 150,000

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Lebanese live within the “security zone” Israel has established (covering about ten percent of Lebanon’s territory), while some 900,000 people reside in the entire south, including the cities of Sidon, Nabatiyya, and Tyre. Plunked in the middle are the 5,250 soldiers of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) who were deployed to Lebanon in 1978 to oversee the withdrawal of the Israeli forces that invaded Lebanon that year.¹ UNIFIL’s tasks remain largely unaccomplished.

Since the first Arab-Israeli war, Lebanon has been home to large numbers of Palestinians. At present, the Palestinians comprise more than ten percent of Lebanon’s total population of three million. Approximately 100,000 Palestinian civilians fled to Lebanon in 1948 and 1949, and while small numbers of these people were integrated into Lebanese society, many lived in the squalid refugee camps erected along the southern coast in places like Rashidiyya, Burj al-Shimali, and Ayn al-Hilwah, as well as in the environs of Beirut and Tripoli. Especially after the 1967 war, as the fida’iyyin gained momentum in the wake of the defeat of Egypt, Syria, and Jordan, the camps proved a fertile recruitment ground. By then, more than 200,000 Palestinians were resident in Lebanon. The 1969 Cairo agreement, promulgated following serious clashes between the Palestinian forces and the Lebanese army, served to legitimate the establishment of what grew to be a Palestinian state-within-a-state.

Into the 1960s, the Israeli-Lebanese border was porous in both directions. The border was unevenly policed, to the extent that smugglers in towns like al-Khiyam in Lebanon and Metulla in Israel prospered, particularly by moving livestock across the border.

By the 1970s, the border region had grown increasingly tense and violent. After the bloody civil war in Jordan in 1970, the Palestinian fida’iyyin concentrated their forces in Lebanon, and early in the decade the now familiar cycle of violence was operating in full force. Israeli raids across the border became increasingly common as the Arkub region of southeastern Lebanon came to be known as Fatehland. From time to time, the Lebanese army would attempt to assert control over the fida’iyyin, but the Lebanese were themselves conflicted over support for the PLO. Even more important, Arab regional powers like Egypt and Syria lent support to the PLO, thereby further undermining the resolve of the Beirut government to control it. Thus, over time, Lebanon lost effective control of major chunks of Lebanese territory.

Early Confrontations

Until the Lebanese civil war began in 1975, Israeli forays into Lebanon were episodic. With the onset of civil war, the Beirut government lost even the nominal ability to maintain control of its territory. Peppered throughout southern Lebanon are Christian and mixed Christian-Muslim villages, and as the fighting intensified, the southern Christians looked to Israel for support

against the coalition of Lebanese and Palestinian forces led by Kamal Junblat, the Druze leader.

Even prior to the founding of Israel, Zionist strategists had reflected on the possibilities of a marriage of convenience between the Zionists and the Christians of Lebanon. In Moshe Sharett's famous diary, the former prime minister reflected on David Ben-Gurion's designs for the establishment of a Christian state in Lebanon, one that would be a natural ally of Israel. In May 1954, Ben-Gurion once again raised the issue of doing something in Lebanon that would capitalize on Syrian-Iraqi tensions and internal dissension in Syria. Moshe Dayan, then chief of staff of the Israeli armed forces, who attended the meeting, reacted enthusiastically. Sharett writes:

According to [Dayan] the only thing that's necessary is to find an officer, even just a Major. We should either win his heart or buy him with money, to make him agree to declare himself the savior of the Maronite population. Then the Israeli army will occupy the necessary territory, and will create a Christian regime which will ally itself with Israel. The territory from the Litani southward will be totally annexed to Israel and everything will be all right. If we were to accept the advice of the Chief of Staff we would do it tomorrow. . . . I [Sharett] did not want to bicker with Ben Gurion . . . in front of his officers and limited myself to saying that this might mean . . . war between Israel and Syria. . . . At the same time I agreed to set up a joint commission composed of officials of the Foreign Affairs Ministry and the Army to deal with Lebanese affairs. . . . The Chief of Staff [i.e., Dayan] supports a plan to hire a [Lebanese] officer who will agree to serve as a puppet so that the Israeli army may appear as responding to his appeal "to liberate Lebanon from its Muslim oppressors." This will of course be a crazy adventure. . . . We must try to prevent dangerous complications. The commission must be charged with research tasks and prudent actions directed at encouraging Maronite circles who reject Muslim pressures and agree to lean on us.²

The civil war in Lebanon would provide an officer—and, by coincidence, a major at that—who would play the role that Dayan had envisaged two decades earlier. By 1974, in the electrically tense period preceding the descent into civil war, Israeli intelligence officials met with members of Tanzim, a Maronite militia group. In the spring of 1975 contacts accelerated between Israel and Christian officers based in southern Lebanon. Although the policy was not officially acknowledged until June 1976, in 1975 Israel initiated its "Good Fence" policy whereby friendly Lebanese were offered access to medical care, relief supplies, and even employment through a series of gates along the Israeli-Lebanese border.

Concurrently, an alliance of sorts emerged between Israel and the predominantly Maronite militias. For the militias, Israel was an important source of arms and ammunition, while for Israel the militias proved to be a steady source of intelligence. According to one estimate, Israel provided as much as \$50 million per year (prior to 1982) to the militias of Bashir Jumayyil and Dany Sham'un, though this sum must be put in perspective: The Lebanese war society devoured about \$900 million per year, of which

\$400 million was in the form of political patronage monies transferred by outside actors, excluding the PLO. The PLO was said to add another \$300 million.³ A less well-known, but important relationship, mediated by Druze citizens of Israel, also existed between Israel and some Lebanese Druze. In point of fact, many of the Israeli officers who act as advisors to the proxy forces are Druze, and Lebanese Druze move relatively freely across the border.

The fault lines of confessionalism ran through the Lebanese army, and the army's coherence fell victim to the civil war. Those army units that remained loyal to the central command did so by studiously backing away from involvement. Individual soldiers, and in some cases, entire units, attached themselves to militias or came to comprise more or less autonomous militias in their own right. In many cases, groups of soldiers simply returned to their villages, and, in the case of several poor villages in the south with a strong tradition of military service, sizable numbers of angry Christian soldiers organized to protect their homes and villages. Hatred of the PLO, and hatred of Lebanese Muslims, who were viewed as PLO supporters, was widely expressed, so Israel seemed a natural ally.

Israel was prepared to exploit the opportunity for its own interests, and commenced to build bonds of dependency between the border Christian villages and the IDF. As Ahmad Beydoun notes in a compelling personal account, Israel's goal seems to have been to "cut the Maronite villages off from their Muslim environment."⁴ Later, the commitment of the IDF's Northern Command to the "Christian enclave" would be a costly blind spot leading to momentous blunders vis-à-vis the Shi'i Muslims who dominate in the south numerically.

There is no reason to underestimate the driving enmities that motivated Israel's Lebanese allies, nor should it be presumed that Israel choreographed every act in the south. But the fact remains that Israel's role in planning, initiating, supporting, and directing operations in southern Lebanon was important. Behind a smoke screen of hype and propaganda, the militia forces allied with Israel were unimpressive. There is an insider's remarkable account of Israel's evolving role in southern Lebanon by Beate Hamizrachi, an Israeli journalist who eventually became a liaison officer between the proxy forces and the press.⁵ Several conclusions emerge quite clearly from the text: First, the initiative for military action was often Israeli, not Lebanese. Second, and in the spirit of the Sharett diary, Israeli officials were deeply conscious of the importance of having a Lebanese front man, not only to camouflage Israel's self-interested policy, but to take the heat for brutality and egregious acts of violence. Third, the driving objective for Israel was security, not economic gain, not access to Lebanese natural resources, and certainly not altruism.

The linchpin for Israel's policy in the south was Sa'ad Haddad, the mercurial Lebanese major who was propelled into the limelight as the leader of the enclave of Christian border villages. A native of Marjayun and a Greek

Catholic, Haddad was sent to the south under army orders in 1977 and rose over time to become the leader of the proxy forces aligned to Israel. By September 1978, the Lebanese government withdrew its provisional recognition of Haddad, though in the intervening period Haddad could credibly claim that he represented legality.⁶ Haddad was a petulant, blustery man given to frequent emotional outbursts ranging from rage to tears. On one occasion, in the midst of an ongoing military operation, he was so out of control that his Israeli counterpart slapped him across the face to bring him to his senses.⁷ His style lent itself to Israel's purposes, since Israeli officials could credibly claim that it was not always easy to control their ally. In one illustrative episode in March 1981, Haddad's forces brutally shelled a United Nations position in a village where his tax- and intelligence-collecting activities were being legitimately and intentionally undermined by the UN. Three UN soldiers died in the shelling, which occurred while all the Israeli officials working in the enclave were said to be away at a meeting and unavailable.⁸ Nonetheless, Hamizrachi argues persuasively that Haddad was virtually a puppet of Israel:

Haddad was never an outstanding military leader whose personal courage was an example to his men. He made mistakes on the tactical level, and without the help of the Israeli officers was often unable to organize, motivate, and sometimes even control his men. The strategic planning for the south and the resulting decisions were made by Israel, based on her own security needs. Haddad had very little input. Though the IDF never saw in Haddad an outstanding military leader, it helped to create an image of him as a tough fighter in the minds of the Israeli people, who developed a special fondness for this man on the other side of the border who talked their political language and fought their battles. The main reason for this phenomenon was the media, whose persistence and continuous interest in Haddad taught him valuable lessons on his way to becoming a positive media personality. The media lifted him from the role of an obscure, town square politician to the position of an international (and particularly an Israeli) media celebrity. The IDF, who knew better, still actively supported the development of this image; a weak and obscure Haddad could only have been counterproductive to its interests and efforts.⁹

A key event in the construction of the "security zone" was Israel's 1978 invasion—"Operation Litani." Following this operation, Haddad's domain grew, as did his notoriety. In March 1978, responding to the Fateh hijacking of a bus that resulted in nine fida'iyyin and 37 Israeli civilian deaths, Israel invaded Lebanon. About 1,100 Lebanese and Palestinians, mostly civilians, perished in the ensuing Israeli assault, which U.S. President Jimmy Carter viewed as an overreaction by Israel. Carter took an adamant position, as he recalls in *The Blood of Abraham*: "I decided that we could not permit Israeli occupation of southern Lebanon to continue. In the event that Begin would not accede to our wishes, we prepared to notify Congress, as required by law, that U.S. weapons were being used illegally in Lebanon, which would have automatically cut off all military aid to Israel. Also, I instructed the State Department to prepare a U.N. Security Council resolution condemning

Israel's action."¹⁰ The U.S. moved aggressively to authorize the creation and the deployment of UNIFIL to oversee the withdrawal of Israel's forces and assist in the restoration of Lebanese government authority in the south. With the exception of the "Tyre-pocket," where the PLO and its allies in the Lebanese National Movement (LNM) would have been tough adversaries, Israel seized all of southern Lebanon up to the Litani river, so it was anticipated that all the area occupied by Israel would be turned over to UNIFIL. But when it came time to withdraw, Israel turned over the border area to Sa'ad Haddad and not to UNIFIL. Major Haddad's border strip or enclave evolved to become the present-day "security zone."

Unfortunately, UNIFIL missteps further complicated things. Although Israel remained in effective control of the border enclave, the UNIFIL commander certified that the IDF had fully withdrawn. This sloppy reporting would haunt UNIFIL for years to come. Moreover, UNIFIL established its headquarters in the old customs station in Naqura, square in the midst of the Israeli-controlled border enclave, and in an area that was not contiguous with the force's area of operations.¹¹ As a result, UN soldiers in Naqura were frequently harassed and often subjected to direct threats and even assaults by Major Haddad's "de facto forces." To add insult to injury, all of the force's sizable contingent of civilian clerks, technicians, and bureaucrats were housed in northern Israel, as was the corps of military observers. Many of the supply lines ran through Israel as well. Of course, the border could be closed at will. Whatever positive contribution UNIFIL may have made to restoring peace to the south has been decisively undermined by the heritage of these early questionable decisions.

One of UNIFIL's major problems was a self-disabling doctrine on the use of force. In theory as well as in practice, UNIFIL contingents abjure the use of force, except for self-defense. With international legitimacy on its side, UNIFIL has the responsibility to symbolically resist armed action that threatens the accomplishment of its mission, even though no one familiar with the relative strengths of the forces in southern Lebanon would expect it to decisively engage the combatants.

Thus, when the IDF almost nonchalantly drove by the UNIFIL headquarters in June 1982 on its way to Tyre, Sidon, and Beirut, a blockade of the road obviously would have been appropriate, if only to compel the invasion to smash through the UNIFIL lines and thereby emphasize the rejection of the UN's authority. Instead, the UNIFIL commander had his soldiers mimic ostriches, or, literally, "go to ground."

In fact, all of the belligerents of south Lebanon quickly learned that they could often strong-arm UNIFIL without too high a penalty, though there were often striking differences in the toughness of the UNIFIL contingents. A few contingents earned a reputation for pushing back, and these tended to be treated more gingerly by the belligerents. Hundreds of UN soldiers died in the line of duty at the hands of all the contending parties in the south, without exception. The shortcomings of the force and its uneven leadership

should not besmirch the selfless service of many thousands of men and quite a few women who served in southern Lebanon.

Consolidation of the "Security Zone"

Between 1978 and 1982, the border enclave was consolidated. Haddad and the Israelis strictly regulated the movement of UN forces there, and often seized the opportunity to move the border of the enclave northward at UNIFIL's expense. In 1979, Haddad declared the establishment of the Free and Independent Lebanese State. Meanwhile, *al-Quwwat al-Mushtaraka*, the joint forces of the PLO and the LNM, reconsolidated their own positions in the south, and especially in Tyre and the Rashidiyya camp to the south of the city. This phase was characterized by periodic violent clashes and several episodes of extensive shelling on both sides of the border. Particularly intense cross-border exchanges between the PLO and Israel in July 1981 led to the negotiation of a cease-fire by U.S. Ambassador Philip Habib.

Israeli officials, like army commander Rafael Eytan, chafed under the cease-fire. In Eytan's view, the longer it was adhered to by the PLO, the more the PLO would be legitimated as a diplomatic actor. This was hardly the goal of the Israeli leadership, which reflexively referred to the PLO as a terrorist organization. Thus, when Israeli Ambassador Shlomo Argov was seriously wounded in an assassination attempt in 1982, Israel claimed that the PLO had abrogated the cease-fire and launched the 1982 invasion, Operation Peace for Galilee. In point of fact, the gunmen who shot Argov were followers of Abu Nidal (the extremist dissident who is a blood enemy of Yasir Arafat and the mainline PLO), sent, apparently, under Iraqi orders.¹²

In any case, throughout the spring of 1982, it was an open secret that Israel was poised to invade. For Prime Minister Menahem Begin and Defense Minister Ariel Sharon, the time had come to destroy the PLO, the organizational impediment to Israel's effective annexation of "Judea," "Samaria," and Gaza (i.e., the occupied West Bank and the Gaza Strip). The Palestinians of the territories were, it was thought, too petrified to challenge the PLO's authority, but once the PLO was cut down to size, things would change. Moreover, with a peace treaty with Egypt secured, the time was ripe for the Lebanese to make peace with Israel. This would further isolate the Syrians, while lending weight to the notion that if Palestinian aspirations for independence were to be consummated, it would be in Jordan.

The Israeli invasion of Lebanon—Operation Peace for Galilee—presumed that the emergent government in Beirut would not only be willing to make peace, but would be capable of doing so. On both counts, presumptions fell short. Even before the Maronite victory of Bashir Jumayyil and his Lebanese Forces militia, which came on the coattails of the Israeli victory, it became patent that Jumayyil did not wish to jeopardize his political position by signing a treaty with Israel. In fact, he contrasted himself to Haddad whom he, like his father Pierre, viewed as a traitor. When Bashir met Sa'ad Haddad in

Israel's Northern Command headquarters in 1982, he refused to shake the major's hand, instructing an aide to "shake his hand for me, will you."¹³ If Jumayyil wished an external sponsor, it was not Israel but the United States. The spurning of Israel has irretrievably discredited the Lebanese Christians in the eyes of Israeli decision-makers, to the extent that references to them are now usually tinged with contempt. Indeed, Israel's misadventure in Lebanon is often explained, in part at least, by the alleged deceitfulness of the Maronites.

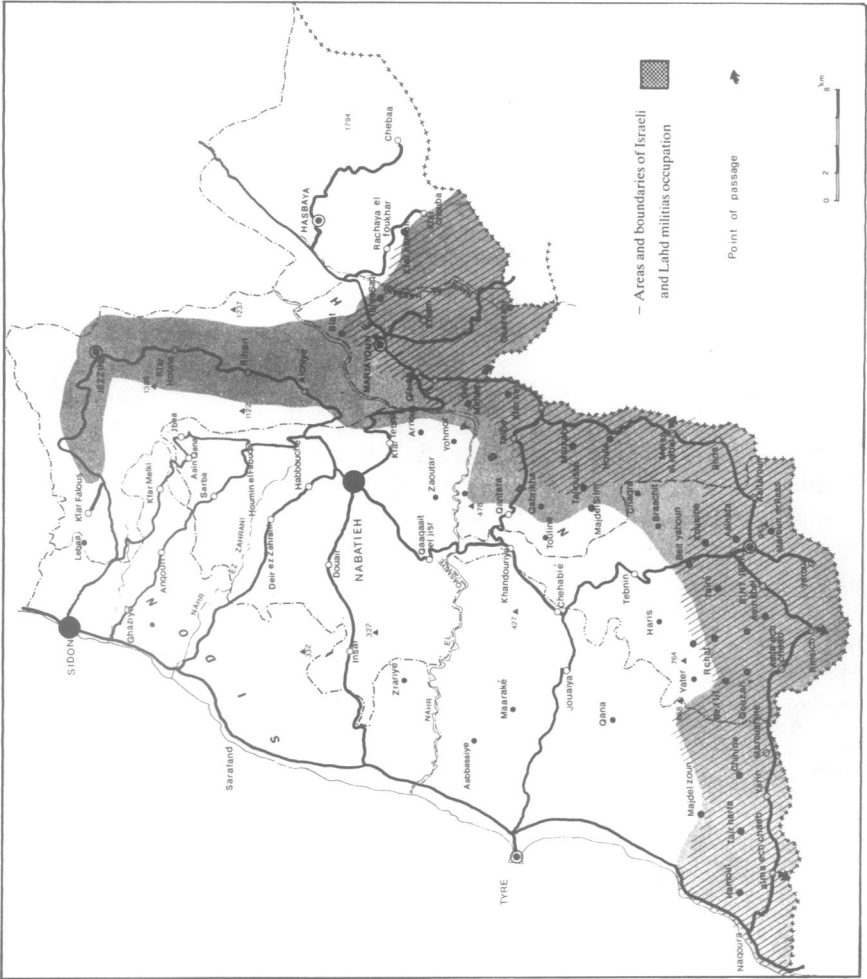
After Bashir's assassination in September 1982, his brother Amin succeeded him. Bereft of wide support in the Maronite community, Amin was even less willing than his brother to sign on the dotted line with Israel. Most astonishing of all, the new government in Beirut seemed to proceed on the assumption that the increasingly assertive Shi'i community could be stifled. The government's failure to integrate emergent Shi'i voices would prove to be one of its most grievous errors. The autumn of 1982, even after the horrible massacres at Sabra and Shatila, was a time of stunning optimism.¹⁴ The fragile basis of the Amin Jumayyil government was shielded from view. American diplomats and key Lebanese officials, hard though they worked to solidify peace, operated with an incomplete conception of Lebanon that ignored contending demands for justice.

One of the strangest diplomatic exercises in recent years was the negotiation of the agreement of 17 May 1983 by U.S. Secretary of State George Shultz. The agreement provided, according to a secret protocol, that Israel would meet its commitment to withdraw from Lebanon only if Syrian forces were simultaneously withdrawn. As Caspar Weinberger, who was then U.S. secretary of defense, later observed: "Why such an agreement was reported to us in such glowing terms by George Shultz has always remained a mystery to me. This agreement with its secret side letter gave President Assad of Syria veto power over any withdrawal and thus over Israel's ability to establish better relations with a key Arab neighbor, Lebanon."¹⁵ The 17 May agreement, though it was subsequently not ratified and, in fact, was abrogated in 1984 by the Lebanese parliament, remains an instructive document in that it provides a clear outline of the conditions under which Israel envisages withdrawal from the south. In effect, the terms of the agreement provide for the Lebanese to agree to the establishment of a "security region" which would be policed by limited Lebanese forces into which the SLA would be integrated. A "Security Arrangements Committee" encompassing Israeli, Lebanese, and U.S. participants would be established to monitor and verify compliance with the agreement.¹⁶ Theoretically, Lebanon would retain the sole right to dispatch military and police forces on its territory. The main complaint against the agreement was that, in practice, given the restrictions on Lebanese force deployments, overflights, and military maneuvers, and given the integration of the Israeli-controlled proxy forces into a "territorial brigade," the south would, de facto, fall under Israeli control.

Israel's persistent preoccupation in Lebanon was, of course, the PLO. This helps, perhaps, to explain why the Israelis, for all of the resources they devoted to PLO-watching in Lebanon, were so obviously ignorant of political developments in Lebanon. Later, as the ill-starred invasion started to unravel, leading Israeli politicians would speak as though emerging political forces like the Shi'i Muslims had arisen spontaneously, thus betraying a deep ignorance of what had been underway in Lebanon for years. In addition, many of the Israelis working as agents in the south were strongly influenced by the opinions of the Christian militia leaders with whom they rubbed elbows; for these thuggish men, the Shi'a were still simply the dirty peasants, beggars, and rough laborers of their stereotypes.

In fact, of course, the Shi'a had been emerging as a major political force in Lebanon by the late 1970s. The Amal movement, originally established in 1974 as a militia adjunct to al-Sayyid Musa al-Sadr's Movement of the Disinherited, had been rejuvenated and rapidly gained adherents in the south and in Shi'i communities throughout Lebanon. Though initially allied with and trained by the PLO, Amal by the end of the 1970s was at odds with the Palestinians and their Lebanese allies: the price of PLO domination in its state-within-a-state in south Lebanon had become too high. Skirmishes, then serious battles were fought between Amal militiamen and elements of the PLO. Oddly, the Israelis did not seem to grasp that the Shi'a, in their current enmity towards PLO, were in fact objective allies. To the contrary, it was sometimes as though the IDF were intent on humiliating the Shi'a and provoking them.¹⁷ The result of this fundamental misjudgment was a phenomenally successful resistance movement which succeeded in forcing Israel to retreat from most of Lebanon in 1985.

In January 1985, the Israeli cabinet decided to conduct a staged withdrawal. The rump of the Israeli invasion would be the "security zone," where the SLA under the command of retired Major General Antoine Lahad, who had replaced Sa'ad Haddad when he succumbed to cancer in 1984, would look after Israeli security. (Earlier, Lahad had been a business partner of former Lebanese Armed Forces Commander General Ibrahim Tannous.) The dimensions of the "security zone" that emerged are shown on the map accompanying this article. In contrast to the pre-1982 enclave, the new "security zone" encroached dramatically upon the UN zone. In fact, in the east, the "security zone" would encompass the entire area of operations of the Norwegian contingent, a fact that would lead to endless friction between Israel and Norway. Leading Israeli officials, notably Uri Lubrani, the coordinator of Israeli affairs in Lebanon, preferred to eliminate UNIFIL south of the Litani river except as a symbolic presence. Lubrani envisaged deploying the force to the north, in effect to create a buffer zone north of the Zahrani river, thereby leaving the far south to Israeli domination.¹⁸ Following the 1985 withdrawals, the SLA maintained a strategic position at Jezzín, well north of the "security zone." Jezzín has obvious military value, but, equally impor-



tant, Jezzín allows continued easy access to the Shuf, where the Druze predominate, as well as the strategically crucial Biqa' valley.

Current Trends in the Balance of Power

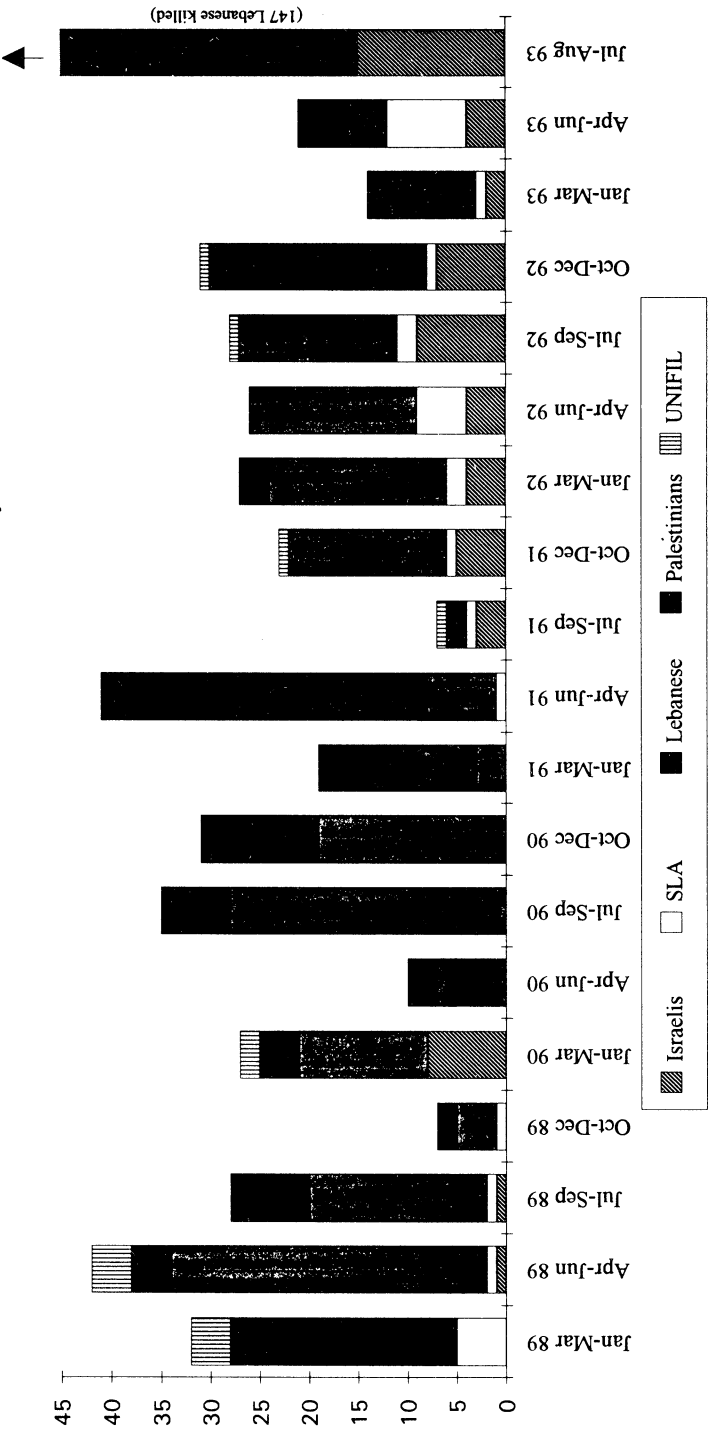
As though a reminder were needed, the fighting of the summer of 1993 serves to illustrate the dangers inherent in the present situation. For its part, Israel's costs have been tolerable over the past several years. Following the high-water mark of 1984-85, when the resistance was extraordinarily deadly, Israeli security officials learned from their losses, and established a security structure in which the exposure of Israeli soldiers was minimized. For all practical purposes, the soldiers of the SLA became sandbags for an Israeli bunker. Learning was not restricted to the IDF. By the late 1980s, the resistance, increasingly synonymous with Hizballah, began to find chinks in Israel's style of operations. As the chart shows, though there have been a number of SLA casualties and Israeli casualties, the real losers in the south have been civilians.¹⁹

In the early part of July 1993, tensions in the south began to escalate following the death of two Israeli soldiers by a roadside bomb inside the "security zone." Clashes intensified over the next weeks, leaving seven Israeli soldiers dead. On 25 July 1993, while Rabin reiterated Israel's dedication to the peace process, Israel launched "Operation Accountability" in southern Lebanon with the objective of flattening Hizballah bases and curtailing guerrilla operations emanating from areas north of the "security zone." Israeli air, ground, and naval forces bombed a wide swath of towns and villages inside and north of the "security zone." Reportedly, 147 Lebanese were killed, most confirmed as civilians, and more than 350,000 fled to Beirut. Some 75 villages as well as much of the regional infrastructure were devastated during the seven-day campaign.

The Israeli bombardment and Hizballah retaliatory attacks on northern Israel did not end until 31 July, when U.S. Secretary of State Warren Christopher brokered a cease-fire agreement. Hizballah agreed to refrain from firing katyusha rockets into northern Israel as long as Israel stopped bombing Lebanese villages. Implicitly, the parties agreed that attacks inside the "security zone" that did not target civilians fell outside of the cease-fire agreement.

The actions and responses invoked by the campaign illustrate some current trends in the regional balance of power. For Israel, the operation was hardly an unvarnished success. The immediate impact was a flood of negative press coverage for Israel, with wide circulation given to a collection of unvarnished statements of intent. Uri Lubrani, Israel's leading Lebanon expert, for example, stated that the purpose of the operation was "to drive home a point." He continued, "Lebanese government, you claim you want to exercise authority over all Lebanese territory. You tell us to take you seriously in your negotiations. Go to your masters [Syria] and tell them: 'Let me decide on my own fate.'"²⁰ Rabin was even clearer when he told the Knes-

War-related Deaths in Lebanon, Quarterly 1989-93



set's foreign affairs and defense committee on 28 July that Israel sought to "provoke an exodus of inhabitants from southern Lebanon towards the north in order to put pressure on the Lebanese government"²¹ to end Hizballah's anti-Israeli activities. "If they continue to attack our towns we will pursue them everywhere and not one of them will be immune. We will attack without mercy and without pause."²² These statements, combined with television and print images of forlorn Lebanese families fleeing their homes for Beirut, did little to generate support for Israel's bombardments.

Inside Israel, the attack may have won support for Rabin's Labor coalition government, which has been under attack for being too "soft" on the Arabs and unresponsive to the needs of Israeli citizens residing in border settlements. While some leading Israeli intellectuals were vocal in their condemnations of the operation, Rabin's government remained preferable to a Likud alternative. Therefore, despite the initial harsh criticism inside Israel, Rabin's government is more likely to be strengthened than weakened by the operation.

The Israeli attack certainly did not improve Israel's image in the eyes of Lebanese civilians. And while Hizballah is not topping any popularity polls in Lebanon either, it gained in popular support by demonstrating a capacity to go toe-to-toe with the IDF. More important, the attacks have not substantially weakened Hizballah, even in the short term: the organization was back in operation in short order, with further deadly attacks within weeks on Israeli soldiers inside the "security zone."

For *Lebanon*, the Israeli operation at a minimum pushed back the prospects for the country's reconstruction. Still, the nationwide response to yet another refugee crisis is instructive. Judging from the Lebanese press, as well as from the comments of Lebanese across the confessional spectrum, the Israeli attacks evoked an uncommon unity of views in sympathy with the victimized south and against Israel. The government, not yet a year old, mobilized the Lebanese army to respond promptly to the flood of refugees in Beirut. For perhaps the first time, the national unity envisioned in the Ta'if Accord of 1989, which provided a framework for ending the civil war, took shape in response to a national crisis. Hundreds of Hizballah militants bearing shovels greeted returning refugees in the south, ready to help civilians dig their way into their devastated homes and begin a massive cleanup campaign. Even followers of General Michel Aoun, who now lives in exile in France, having been deposed by Syrian guns in the autumn of 1990, responded with words of support for the people of the south, as well as with financial aid.

Although the government did react with unusual decisiveness in the recent crisis, the fact remains that it has been virtually unable to control Hizballah. Some Israeli officials claim that the attacks did succeed in increasing the Lebanese government's margin of control over Hizballah activities, and that the Lebanese army began establishing road blocks in the south following the cease-fire, halting weapons shipments, and even confiscating some katyusha rocket launchers from Hizballah. Nonetheless, the Lebanese army was un-

able to sustain these gains. Moreover, although many Lebanese members of parliament support disarming Hizballah, the parliament elected in 1992 is also decidedly pro-Syrian, and Damascus has considerable say as to when and if Hizballah raids in the south are to cease. The parliament is further hampered in responding directly to Hizballah activities, since the Islamist bloc comprises the largest single bloc in parliament.

Following the cease-fire agreement, Lebanon's Higher Defense Council (HDC) revoked weapons licenses for some 20,000 to 40,000 firearms, and authorized Prime Minister Rafiq Hariri, as HDC chairman, to determine new criteria for issuing new permits. A few days later, Defense Minister Mohsin Dallul declared that permits signed by the defense minister would remain valid. While the apparent reversal of policy may represent no more than bureaucratic infighting, it was widely perceived as yet another example of Syrian pressure. According to some Syrian officials, Beirut was being too forthcoming in its move to regain control of the south without adequate prior consultation with Damascus. For Syria, disarming resistance fighters—namely Hizballah—without a hefty prize from Israel would constitute the wasting of a valuable negotiating card.

As expected, Syria played a key role in the cease-fire agreement. Damascus effectively reiterated its intention to keep its hand on the Lebanon switch until Israel withdraws from its "security zone."

Within Iran, Hizballah's sponsors may claim vindication: How is it possible, they might ask, to negotiate with a state whose operations are aimed at driving as many people from their homes as possible? Certainly, the events of the summer of 1993 will be used in internal debates to justify continued funding of Hizballah campaigns in the "security zone," though Iran will arguably find it difficult to be the odd man out should the process generate a series of peace treaties between Israel and its neighbors. At that time, Iran may be forced to reevaluate its patronage of Hizballah. For the present, however, Israel's attacks, particularly those inflicting civilian casualties, serve to substantiate Iranian claims that Hizballah activities are not only justified but necessary.

With respect to the *United States*, the Israeli-Hizballah exchanges shook the State Department out of a summer idyll vis-à-vis the peace process, and offered an opportunity for Secretary of State Christopher to broker a cease-fire. The Arab parties to the negotiations have consistently raised questions about Washington's alleged double standard in responding to campaigns in the "security zone" and beyond, and these criticisms were levelled yet again. Following Israel's July attack, Washington refused to indicate whether it had received early notice of the attacks, but if official statements are an indication, Washington clearly approved: State Department and White House spokespersons blamed Hizballah rather than Israel for the violence, and called for disarming the organization.

Many Lebanese officials viewed the 1 July 1993 U.S. Senate resolution that called for the redeployment of Syrian troops from Lebanon (as required in

the Ta'if accord) as yet another example of Washington's one-sided perspective on Lebanese affairs, in that the resolution made no mention of Israel's presence in south Lebanon. The following week, feeding apprehensions, U.S. Special Coordinator Dennis Ross snubbed Lebanon by excluding it from his six-day tour of the neighboring countries. On 21 July, Beirut learned that Christopher also intended to skip Lebanon during a trip to the region in early August. Lebanese officials conclude, accurately, that Washington feels resolution of the Israeli-Lebanese question is secondary to progress on the Syrian and Palestinian fronts.

Nevertheless, Washington was eager to keep the peace talks on track, and Clinton made a gesture to demonstrate his objectivity, praising Syria for showing "commendable restraint"²³ following the Israeli attacks in July 1993. The official Lebanese response to the bombardments was likewise restrained, perhaps because it had few options. At Washington's insistence, according to reports from Beirut, Lebanon withdrew its request to the UN Security Council for a special session to address Israeli aggression in the south. After the cease-fire, Beirut was rewarded for not pressing its complaints at the UN. Contrary to his original plans, Christopher visited Zahle in early August bearing the message that "America cares about Lebanon."²⁴

On 19 August, less than three weeks after the cease-fire agreement, Hizballah guerrillas detonated several road-side bombs inside the "security zone," killing nine Israeli soldiers in two separate attacks. Israel responded with air strikes against Hizballah bases near the Syrian border, but with fewer and lighter attacks than during its July bombings. Unlike during Operation Accountability, Israel's retaliatory measures were aimed at Hizballah bases in sites unpopulated by civilians. Israel's comparative restraint underlined its explicit acknowledgement that the cease-fire did not restrict attacks inside the "security zone." In general, the resistance has directed its attacks against the "security zone" and against Israel's presence in Lebanon, rather than against Israel per se. This operational code has been buttressed by the terms of the cease-fire.

Lebanon as Pawn in the Regional Game

With all the preceding as background, the key question is the circumstances under which Israel will dismantle the "security zone." Unfortunately, the prospects for a separate deal or some diplomatic sleight of hand are slim to none. Some observers fantasize about Washington issuing a diktat demanding that Israel withdraw, but the chances of this happening are equally slim.

Following the implementation of the Ta'if accord, which facilitated the dismantling (after a fashion) of all the militias except the Iranian-backed Hizballah and the Israeli-backed SLA, and coincident with the restoration of an effective government in Beirut, the Lebanese government became more assertive in its calls for the withdrawal of Israeli forces from the south and the

dismantling of the "security zone." The government rested its demands on the uncomplicated and unambiguous language of UN Security Council Resolution 425 of 1978, supported by the United States, which calls upon Israel to "withdraw forthwith its forces from all Lebanese territory." Unlike the case of Gaza and the West Bank, Israel purports to have no claim on Lebanese territory, arguing instead that its interests are confined to security along its borders. But Israel, unwilling to buttress a Beirut government that it saw as a puppet of the Syrians, was certainly not enticed by the possibility that the Lebanese army in cooperation with UN forces would look after Israel's security interests. Moreover, Israel could not be much impressed by any withdrawal arrangement that left Hizballah intact. Instead, there was a consensus amongst Israeli officials: the "security zone" was a successful and relatively low-cost venture.

Thus, the Lebanese discovered, once again, that their situation was deeply enmeshed in the geopolitics of the region, and particularly the relationship between Syria and Israel. Despite profound misgivings centering on the concern that Lebanon might become a course on the menu of an Israeli-Syrian banquet, the Lebanese joined the U.S.-shepherded peace talks which began in Madrid in the autumn of 1991, though Beirut followed the lead of Damascus and declined to participate in the multilateral component. Arguably, the decision not to participate in any of the multilateral negotiations represented the forfeiting of an opportunity to distinguish Lebanese interests from Syrian ones.

There is no mistaking the fact that, the appearance of Israeli-Lebanese bilateral discussions notwithstanding, the fate of southern Lebanon remains hostage to the game of move and countermove between Damascus and Tel Aviv. There is no difficulty in reading the basic security interests of the two adversaries, although the design of an agreement is no mean task. South Lebanon is linked geographically and strategically to the Golan Heights, so the challenge is to link the two areas in a comprehensive agreement which satisfies Syrian demands for a return of the Golan with Israeli demands for the demilitarization of large chunks of Syrian territory adjacent to the Heights. This type of agreement is probably a necessary condition for an Israeli withdrawal from south Lebanon.

Even so, Israel remains to be convinced that a security structure in south Lebanon which it does not control can provide a better guarantee of its security than one which it does control (viz., the "security zone"). No doubt, as noted above, the 17 May 1983 agreement, in which the south remains permeable to Israeli oversight, remains an instructive guide to Israeli objectives. For its part, Syria has a compelling military interest in protecting its Lebanese flank. Therefore, it is not inconceivable that the Israelis and the Syrians might more readily reach agreement on the Golan than in south Lebanon. In fact, the status quo in south Lebanon may actually be preferable to both parties.

For Syria, the maintenance of an Israeli position in southern Lebanon would serve as a significant justification for the continuing presence of Syrian military forces in Lebanon. For Israel, the design of a security framework for the Golan Heights is conceptually much simpler than the creation of an effective security framework in south Lebanon, where neither the Lebanese army nor the UN forces will meet Israel's reliability demands. In contrast, the extant UN force—the United Nations Disengagement Observer Force (UNDOF)—has functioned smoothly in a setting where both belligerents have shared an interest in maintaining stability. One can easily imagine a buttressing of UNDOF to police demilitarized zones on the Golan; it is not easily possible to envisage a comparable buttressing in southern Lebanon.

If it is relatively easy to read the security interests of the two belligerents, reading their metaphysical commitments is more complicated. Syria's attitude toward Lebanon's sovereignty and independence is a major question. Syrian preponderance is amply illustrated by intensive coordination of positions. There has been apprehension—lent credibility by Zionist archival sources—that Israel covets south Lebanon's water resources, but there is still no concrete evidence to prove that Israel is now, or is preparing in the future, to siphon off or divert the water of the Litani.²⁵ In writings on the waters of the Litani, one finds much more theology than hydrology.

For Lebanon, of course, so long as the south continues to be occupied, the government in Beirut will continue to be thwarted in its efforts to demilitarize Lebanese society. In effect, the full restoration of tranquility and prosperity to Lebanon is conditional on an end to the occupation of South Lebanon. Indeed, the radicalization of the large Shi'i population reflects, more or less directly, the status of the south. Although the armed Palestinian presence in Lebanon has been reduced significantly in scope, a population of over 300,000 Palestinian civilians reside in Lebanon and their fate too is hostage to the situation in the south. The fact is that Israel is unlikely to agree, soon at least, to the repatriation of the Palestinians living in Lebanon. Most of these people, at any event, trace their roots to Haifa and the Upper Galilee, not to the West Bank and Gaza. No doubt, a significant stumbling block in negotiations between Israel and Lebanon will be the resolution of the fate of this community. Lebanon's acceptance of the integration of these 300,000 Palestinians into Lebanese society may be the only answer that Israel will accept, but the decision would be profoundly problematic in domestic Lebanese terms. Most of the Palestinian residents in Lebanon are Sunni Muslims, and their addition to the confessional melange would likely be resisted by Lebanese Christians as well as by Shi'i Muslims.

Absent an Israeli-Syrian agreement, it is very unlikely that the south will be restored to the effective control of the Lebanese government. This does not mean, it must be emphasized, that Lebanon must blithely wait for the peace train to arrive. In the meantime, steps are underway to expand the presence of the Lebanese army in the south, though this is only a marginal factor. The buttressing of the international forces (UNIFIL) is no panacea,

and, in fact, most of the troop-contributing governments would like to find an exit from Lebanon. Serious attention needs to be given to efforts that might serve as a catalyst in the diplomatic process, steps which put south Lebanon squarely on the international agenda.

The irony that runs through this discussion is that Lebanon's position is incontestable. UN Security Council Resolutions 425 and 509 (the June 1982 resolution, unanimously approved, which "[d]emands that Israel withdraw all its military forces forthwith and unconditionally to the internationally recognized boundaries of Lebanon") are unambiguous. Several years ago, some circles, particularly in Washington, saw the south as the starting point for the peace process. The idea, simply put, was that since Israel makes no explicit territorial claims on Lebanon, and since the Israeli-Lebanese border was fixed in a 1949 armistice accord, the question of southern Lebanon was structurally much simpler than the case of the Palestinians.

In practice, of course, the situation is not nearly so simple. There is no magic diplomatic wand and no quick solution. Instead, the answer lies in the long-term construction of a sturdy security framework that must serve three ends: it must provide a stable and safe environment for the Lebanese citizens of the south; it must address the legitimate security concerns of Syria; and it must address the legitimate security concerns of Israel. Lebanon cannot afford to ignore the interests of its two powerful neighbors. Ultimately, however, the Lebanese must recognize that Lebanon's interests are identical neither with Israel's nor with Syria's.

Lebanese officials worry, justifiably, that Lebanon stands at the back of the peace queue. The Palestinians and Jordanians are moving toward settlements with Israel, and Lebanon will be deeply affected by the agreements struck. Thus, prudence dictates a reexamination of Lebanon's diplomatic posture to ensure that the price of peace is not borne disproportionately by itself. While one can empathize with the anxiety of Lebanese officials contemplating a divergence from Syria's "brotherly guidance," there can be no doubt that Lebanon must assertively state its claims and its sovereign prerogatives. Otherwise, Israel (and many U.S. officials) will persist in treating Lebanon as a sanjak of Syria. The Lebanese must, to be blunt, resolve to save themselves.

Business as usual in south Lebanon is a commerce in killing and mayhem. One can only hope that the violence and the massive dislocations of the summer of 1993 may not have been for naught, if the Lebanese and the Israelis can focus, together, on the "security zone" as an impediment to moderation—a pathology, not a cure—then peace may have a chance in south Lebanon as well. The risk, in this moment of peace-process euphoria, is that Lebanon will be the last frontier in the Arab-Israeli conflict, in effect, the hold box for those problems that are too tough to solve.

NOTES

1. These soldiers are drawn from ten countries, as of July 1993: Fiji, Finland, France, Ghana, Ireland, Italy, Nepal, Norway, Poland, and Sweden.
2. These diary entries from May 1954 are from Livia Rokach, *Israel's Sacred Terrorism: A Study Based on Moshe Sharett's Personal Diary and other Documents* (Belmont, MA: Association of Arab-American University Graduates, 1980), p. 29.
3. American Task Force for Lebanon, *Working Paper—Conference on Lebanon, June 27-30, 1991* (Washington, D.C.: American Task Force for Lebanon, 1991), pp. 26 and 53.
4. Ahmad Beydoun, "The South Lebanon Border Zone: A Local Perspective," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 21, no. 3 (Spring 1992), p. 41.
5. Beate Hamizrachi, *The Emergence of the South Lebanon Security Belt: Major Saad Haddad and the Ties with Israel, 1975-1978* (New York: Praeger, 1988). Ms. Hamizrachi's husband Yoram was an Israeli intelligence officer who served as Haddad's nominal counterpart. In fact, as this book corroborates, he often called the shots.
6. See Bjørn Skogmo, *UNIFIL: International Peacekeeping in Lebanon, 1978-1988* (Boulder and London: Lynne Rienner Publishers, 1989), pp. 22-23.
7. Hamizrachi, p. 150.
8. Personal knowledge of the author, who was involved on the United Nations side. Later, it was discovered that Israeli soldiers were present while the shelling was underway. Haddad's de facto forces, so named because the United Nations did not recognize their legitimacy, but noted their existence, were condemned in a UN Security Council statement for their role in the shelling, while addressing a "serious warning to all forces responsible for these dangerous events." See Security Council document 14414, March 19, 1981.
9. Hamizrachi, p. 184.
10. Jimmy Carter, *The Blood of Abraham: Insights into the Middle East* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Co., 1985), p. 97.
11. For a vivid depiction of UNIFIL in south Lebanon see Robert Fisk, *Pity the Nation: The Abduction of Lebanon* (New York: Atheneum, 1990), pp. 134-59.
12. See Ze'ev Schiff and Ehud Ya'ari, ed. and trans. Ida Friedman, *Israel's Lebanon War* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1984), pp. 97-101.
13. Schiff and Ya'ari, p. 131.
14. Augustus Richard Norton, "The Political Mood in Lebanon," *Middle East Insight* 2, no. 5 (January-February 1983), pp. 9-13.
15. Caspar W. Weinberger, *Fighting for Peace: Seven Critical Years in the Pentagon* (New York: Warner Books, 1990), pp. 165-66.
16. For text of the May 17 agreement see the *Journal of Palestine Studies* 12, no. 4 (Summer 1983), pp. 91-101.
17. See Augustus Richard Norton, "Making Enemies in South Lebanon: Harakat Amal, the IDF, and South Lebanon," *Middle East Insight* 3, no. 3 (1984), pp. 13-20; and, idem., *Amal and the Shi'a*.
18. Uri Lubrani, "Israel, Syria and Lebanon—An Israeli Perspective," *Middle East Insight* 4, no. 1 (1985), pp. 10-13; also see Efraim Inbar, "Great Power Mediation: The USA and the May 1983 Israeli-Lebanese Agreement," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 28, no. 1 (February 1991): 71-84. Inbar notes the Israeli government's negotiating position of 10 October 1982 on p. 75. In addition to the evacuation of the PLO, and the simultaneous withdrawal of Syrian forces, "What Israel wanted in southern Lebanon was a 45-50 km demilitarized zone, freedom of air surveillance, three early warning stations, and, in the absence of an effective Lebanese army force, reliance on the Israeli-backed militia led by Major Saad Haddad to ensure security. Typical of the Israeli mistrust of foreign guarantees, the presence of international forces such as UNIFIL or a MNF was rejected."
19. Israeli and SLA casualties have been roughly comparable in recent years, and in some periods IDF losses have considerably exceeded reported SLA losses. This trend is in contrast to the years immediately following the IDF withdrawal of 1985, when SLA losses were much higher. For instance, 64 SLA and 12 IDF soldiers were killed in 1987, while 30 SLA and 15 IDF soldiers were killed in 1988.
20. *Boston Globe*, 29 July 1993.
21. *Lebanon Report* 4, no. 8 (July 1993), p. 3.
22. *New York Times*, 29 July 1993, p. A14.
23. *Mideast Mirror*, 28 July 1993, p. 2.
24. *New York Times*, 5 August 1993, p. A6.
25. The water question is nicely summarized by Fida Nasrallah, *The Questions of South Lebanon*, Prospects for Lebanon no. 5 (Oxford: Centre for Lebanese Studies, May 1992), pp. 9-13.